

Assessment of Project Management Tools

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Executive Summary

The Maritime Heritage Society of Prince Edward Island is developing a browser based information system to manage historical ship records and archival materials. The project must be completed within nine months and remain within a total budget of \$185,000, with an additional \$35,000 reserved for contingencies. To support project coordination and financial control, the team evaluated six project management software platforms: MS Project, Genius Project, Teamwork, ClickUp, Trello, and Basecamp, to determine which tool best supports two essential project management activities: developing a Project Communication Plan and tracking the Project Budget.

Across the six platforms, each tool offered a different balance of usability, communication features, and budgeting capabilities. MS Project provided advanced scheduling and cost-tracking functions but required substantial training and additional Microsoft tools for communication. Genius Project demonstrated strong enterprise-level documentation control and workflow governance but exceeded the technical capacity of a small heritage institution. Trello and Basecamp offered user-friendly task coordination and communication features but lacked the financial tracking and analytical depth required for grant-funded project oversight. Teamwork delivered a mix of communication and budgeting functions but placed several key financial tools behind paid tiers that may challenge nonprofit resource limits.

ClickUp emerged as the most suitable choice because it integrates communication tools, collaborative workspaces, customizable dashboards, and basic budgeting features within a single, low-cost platform. Its flexible views, task-based discussions, notification system, and accessible interface support stakeholders with varying technical experience, including board members, educators, developers, and volunteers. Although advanced financial modeling will still be conducted in Excel, ClickUp provides sufficient cost-tracking fields and reporting visibility to support the project's monthly financial updates and grant compliance requirements.

Based on its overall balance of usability, collaboration features, and cost-tracking capabilities, ClickUp is recommended as the optimal project management solution for the Maritime Archive Information System project.

Section 2:

Our team looked at four project management software platforms: MS Project, Genius Project, ClickUp and Trello, to see if they fit the Maritime Archive Information System project. We checked each software platform for how it can help with two project management tasks: developing a Project Communication Plan and creating and keeping a Project Budget Tracker. The Project Communication Plan and the Project Budget Tracker provide coordination and financial oversight, for the project's nine month timeline and \$185,000 budget.

Section 3:

A nine-month project is being undertaken by the Maritime Heritage Society of Prince Edward Island to create a browser-based information system for managing archival materials dating back to 1825, including logbooks, ship plans, models, and photographs. The project's purpose is to consolidate historical records into a centralized database that reconstructs vessel histories and provides secure public access through a searchable interface. The project is supported by a \$185,000 grant with an additional \$35,000 contingency fund, and its success relies on the coordinated efforts of several key contributors: Society President Isabel Lorentus, Education and Programming Officer Charlotte Ng, and volunteer archivist "Bud" Thompson. Because the project involves diverse stakeholder roles, technical processes, and financial constraints, two project management activities—the Project Communication Plan and the Project Budget Tracker—are essential forms of project control. Section 3 discusses these two activities and explains how they could be completed manually without the use of specialized project management software.

A Project Communication Plan is a structured document that defines how project information will flow among team members throughout the project lifecycle. Its purpose is to ensure that stakeholders receive the correct level of detail, at the appropriate time, through a consistent communication channel. This activity is especially important for this project because stakeholders differ significantly in expertise, responsibilities, and the type of information they require. For example, Isabel Lorentus, as President, oversees grant obligations and organizational governance. She requires regular milestone updates, summaries of completed deliverables, and

high-level financial progress reports to ensure alignment with the terms of the grant. Charlotte Ng, whose responsibilities involve public programming and educational content, needs communication updates related to interface design, accessibility considerations, and decisions affecting how students, museum visitors, and remote users will navigate the system. Bud Thompson, who handles archival materials and digitization, requires frequent updates about scanning workflows, metadata definitions, preservation standards, and sequencing of historical materials being prepared for upload.

These differing needs can be organized manually using a simple spreadsheet-based communication plan. A stakeholder communication table could list each project participant, the type of information they require, the communication frequency (e.g., weekly, bi-weekly, monthly), and the channel used to deliver updates (such as email, shared documents, virtual meetings, or in-person discussions). A timeline or Gantt-style layout could also be created manually to schedule key communication events, ensuring that updates occur consistently and support informed decision-making. By structuring communication in a predictable format, the team reduces the risk of misalignment, overlooked decisions, and delays caused by informal or inconsistent information sharing.

A communication plan created without software would rely on basic tools such as email, document templates, and meeting notes. Standardized agendas, decision logs, and update summaries could be drafted in Microsoft Word or Excel and stored in a shared folder. These documents help ensure that agreements about metadata standards, system functionalities, or archival handling procedures are recorded accurately and can be referenced later. Stakeholder input, including feedback from early testers or Society members, could be gathered through email surveys or brief meetings and captured in the spreadsheet as part of the communication record. Even without specialized software, these manual methods create transparency and accountability for decisions affecting the database's development.

The second key activity, the Project Budget Tracker, provides financial oversight and ensures the project remains within the grant's allocated funds. A budget tracker documents budgeted and actual costs, calculates variances, and identifies spending trends that may affect the project's timeline or scope. This project's budget categories would include labour costs for

software development, archival digitization, database design, and testing; equipment costs for scanners and preservation materials; cloud hosting fees; accessibility evaluations; and public engagement materials. These categories can be maintained manually using an Excel sheet that includes columns for budgeted cost, actual cost, variance, and remaining funds, alongside a separate column for tracking use of the \$35,000 contingency reserve.

Manual budget tracking enables early detection of cost overruns. If equipment costs exceed projections or development labour requires additional hours, the variance column in the spreadsheet would make these discrepancies visible. The project team could then make informed adjustments to the scope or schedule, or allocate part of the contingency fund to prevent the overrun from jeopardizing the project. Monthly financial updates could be generated by exporting the spreadsheet into summary tables or charts and shared with Isabel and the board as part of the communication plan. This approach supports transparency and ensures compliance with grant reporting obligations.

Manual budget tracking also supports basic scenario planning. By projecting remaining costs for labour, testing, or digitization tasks, the project team can estimate whether current spending aligns with the remaining timeline. Simple formulas in Excel—such as average monthly spending rates or burn-down calculations—can indicate whether the project is likely to exceed its budget before completion. These calculations do not provide the depth of automated financial modeling found in specialized software, but they are sufficiently effective for a project of this scale, particularly one operating with volunteer support and a limited administrative structure.

Together, the manual communication plan and budget tracker establish a foundational system of project control for the Maritime Archive Information System. The communication plan ensures that stakeholders receive timely, appropriate information and information remain aligned despite differences in technical background and project responsibilities. The budget tracker provides a clear and organized record of financial performance, allowing the project team to maintain the system within its grant-funded limits. Although more advanced project management software can automate and enhance these activities, both tasks can be executed effectively using simple tools such as spreadsheets, emails, and standard documentation

templates. These manual processes ensure transparency, structure, and oversight, supporting the successful delivery of a secure and accessible historical information system for the Maritime Heritage Society.

Section 4:

1. Genius project

This review is based on official documents from Cerri, the company that made Genius Project, independent software reviews, and tests done with the platform's 15-day free trial version. Genius Project is an enterprise level project and portfolio management system that mid-sized to large companies use to keep track of complicated workflows, documents, budgets, and governance processes (Cerri Project, 2025). The platform has a lot of features, such as managing a project portfolio, keeping track of resources, budgeting, managing risks and changes, managing documents, approval workflows, and working together in real time. These traits make Genius Project theoretically a good fit for businesses that need structured communication oversight and close financial monitoring. This is more in line with the goals of enterprise projects than small, volunteer-driven projects.

To see how well Genius Project helps the Maritime Heritage Society's Information System project, we will look at two project management tasks: the Project Communication Plan and the Project Budget Tracker. Genius Project is great at supporting a formal communication plan because it focuses on controlling documents, approval paths, and structured communication workflows. Users can manage documents, keep track of versions, organize recorded meetings, and set up formal approval processes with the system. All of these things help with communication traceability and accountability (Cerri Project, 2025). In theory, these features could help the Society coordinate communication between board members, teachers, software developers, and archival volunteers by making sure that decisions, records, and updates stay organized and easy to find. External reviews also stress the platform's company-wide focus on workflow discipline and documentation governance, which makes it even better for

communication settings that need to be able to be audited and have structured oversight (Andre, 2025).

Even though Genius Project has these advantages, it might be too complicated for the Society's staffing model. The platform assumes that volunteers and board members know how to use project management methods, enterprise governance structures, and configuration processes, which they may not. Andre (2025) says that Genius Project is best for medium- to large-sized businesses that already have good administrative skills.

The program's many configuration needs may make it hard for small teams to use. The Society may not have the time or knowledge to set up communication workflows, user permissions, document taxonomies, and approval chains. This is especially true because the Society relies on volunteers and needs to focus on digitizing archives, developing metadata, and designing systems within a set time frame. The communication modules are very advanced, which is good in theory, but they would probably require a lot of training, which would slow down the project's progress.

Genius Project also has great tools for keeping track of costs and budgets. The software has parts for tracking expenses, making project budgets, allocating time and resources, and predicting the future of finances (Cerri Project, 2025). These tools help businesses keep track of how well their budgets are doing at different stages of a project, connect costs to resource use, and make financial reports. Genius Project could help keep an eye on costs and make sure that the project stays on budget with a main budget of \$185,000 and a reserve fund of \$35,000. External reviews show that the platform has strong budget and cost management tools, such as connections to time and expense tracking workflows that make it easier to keep an eye on finances (Andre, 2025). These traits make it likely that Genius Project can be used as a full budgeting system for big, well-organized projects.

But just like its communication features, the budgeting tools might not work for the Maritime Heritage Society. To use Genius Project's financial modules well, you need to enter data regularly, get input from stakeholders, and have ongoing administrative oversight. These requirements can be hard to meet in small businesses that don't have

dedicated project control officers or financial administrators. Volunteers might have trouble using the structured budget fields and financial reporting templates, which could make the data input less accurate and consistent. The system's budgeting tools are better than those of many project management tools, but their complexity may not be useful in the real world for a heritage organization that is only managing one software development project.

In summary, Genius Project has a lot of great communication and budgeting tools for businesses that work well in formal project governance settings. It has strong theoretical support for both a Project Communication Plan and a Project Budget Tracker because it has tools for managing risks, tracking costs, and controlling documentation. But these same strengths become weaknesses when used in the context of the Maritime Heritage Society. The platform is too complicated, needs too much administration, and needs to be set up in a way that a small heritage organization with volunteers can't use it. Genius Project is capable, but it doesn't make sense for this project's resources, staff, and size.

2. ClickUp

The critique draws on ClickUp third party reviews and testing within the free version of the platform. ClickUp operates as a cloud based project management solution that unites all communication tools with task management and work tracking features into a single workspace (*ClickUp™ | One App to Replace Them All*, n.d.). The wide range of features in ClickUp makes it an adaptable solution for teams that need to handle both technical work and administrative responsibilities. The Information System for a Maritime Archive project, which involves board members, educators, software developers, and volunteers, can benefit from ClickUp through its suitable features for communication management and budget tracking. The platform generates value through its complex interface design and its basic free version restrictions.

Users must learn the platform's operations through a process that beginners might find complicated. This aligns with external reviews, which note that ClickUp has a steep learning curve for new users (Ionescu, 2023). The platform uses Spaces, Folders, Lists, and Tasks to organize projects, which suits the needs of large, complex initiatives like

building a browser based archival database. The platform enables teams to link discussions with deliverables and deadlines through its structured system after initial setup. The platform offers various viewing choices, along with editing functions, which might create confusion for users who start using the system. The ClickUp project management software interface can create problems for board members and volunteers who do not have project management tool experience, as it contains complex design elements and multiple configuration options. The platform enables users to learn ClickUp through interactive tutorials, pre-built templates (Ionescu, 2023), and simple top level navigation, which creates an enhanced user experience through continuous platform interaction (*ClickUpTM | One App to Replace Them All*, n.d.).

ClickUp enables users to work in a flexible environment that unites attractive visuals with adjustable functionality. The project needs to track progress through ClickUp's combination of status indicators, Kanban boards, Gantt charts, and task dashboards, as it operates under a fixed nine month deadline from the grant. All collaborators receive immediate updates whenever someone makes changes to communication plans, deliverable schedules, or budget information. The system provides full visibility, which enables teams to stay aligned, as it links technical work to archival expertise. The free version of ClickUp displays too many optional views and upgrade prompts, which create interface clutter that distracts users from their essential work activities.

ClickUp offers affordable pricing options that support both public institutions and nonprofit organizations. ClickUp provides unlimited user access through its free version, enabling users to create communication plans and track fundamental budget data (*ClickUpTM | One App to Replace Them All*, n.d.). The Maritime Heritage Society benefits from ClickUp because it supports both paid staff members and unpaid volunteers who participate in the organization. The paid versions of ClickUp offer additional features starting at \$7 per user per month and going up to \$12 per user per month (*ClickUpTM | One App to Replace Them All*, n.d.). The project requirements do not necessitate these additional features, which would increase costs beyond the project's funding capacity.

ClickUp enables users to create and sustain their Project Communication Plans through its suitable working environment. The platform allows users to add task specific comments while working on communication strategy documents and establish notification systems and assign tasks based on responsibility. The system enables stakeholders to monitor all activities that occur during their work across various groups (*ClickUpTM | One App to Replace Them All*, n.d.). TechRadar also highlights that ClickUp functions as an effective collaboration tool, enabling teams to work together efficiently across shared tasks and workspaces (*TechRadar, 2024*).

The Project Budget Tracker module in ClickUp includes basic functionality but it lacks advanced capabilities. The platform allows teams to monitor budget performance through custom fields that display estimated costs against actual expenses and provides dashboards for showing financial data at a high level. The system correctly monitors both the \$185,000 main budget and the \$35,000 reserve fund. However, the platform lacks capabilities for complex financial modeling, so users should use it as a supplement to their existing budgeting software, such as Excel.

ClickUp excels at communication management and cost tracking but its financial precision issues and complex interface design make it better suited for coordination tasks than complete financial management for this project.

3. Trello

This evaluation is based on Trello's official documentation, third party reviews, and hands on testing conducted using the platform's browser based free version. Trello is a browser based project management platform built on the Kanban methodology. It uses boards, lists, and cards to help organize workflow (Siderova, 2018). Its interface is simple and clean, making it easy for team members to understand what is happening without requiring complicated training (Trello, 2025). In terms of the Maritime Heritage archive database system, Trello can act as a planning and coordination space rather than the database itself. Its browser accessibility supports remote collaboration and allows for progress to be tracked easily, without requiring technical or complex training.

Trello has several key features that can help make it highly efficient. First, there is the use of cards. Cards act as a way to keep track of tasks as they enable team members to leave comments and attach important documents (Trello, 2025). This provides a simple and traceable communication history linked to different deliverables, which can help with accountability within the project. Second, there are labels, which help categorize and customize the project elements, such as grouping cards by budget or checkpoints. It uses color-coded tags, allowing for quick filtering and prioritization, keeping the board organized when the number of cards starts to increase. Lastly, Trello can also set due dates, which is important for a project with a 9 month schedule with a fixed completion date (Trello, 2025). This allows team members to see what tasks need to be done and by when to avoid being delayed. Lastly, Trello includes Butler automation, which helps manage the overall board. It can auto-archive completed cards or generate checklists to maintain workflow consistency.

Despite these features, Trello has clear disadvantages when evaluated for this specific project. Its biggest limitation is the lack of setting and tracking the project's budget. While budget cards can document individual costs or link to financial documents, they don't have any feature that calculates or consolidates total project spending. Trello does have a power-up feature that can act as a makeshift way to track financials, but it may not be enough for a project like this (*Power-Ups for Trello*, n.d.). This can lead to missing or inaccurate financial tracking, and would mean that another external software would be needed to track them properly. Trello also lacks a way to visualize task dependencies or generate a critical path. This would be needed to be considered for database development, as some tasks may need to be completed first before others can proceed. Sequencing must be tracked manually, using naming conventions or lists, as Trello does not feature dependency maps within its software. Additionally, Trello can only give out basic output reports, which may not be sufficient if deeper performance insights or fund analytics are needed.

In conclusion, Trello is best used as a planning and coordination layer rather than a software that could handle communication, but not necessarily track the budget. It excels in visual simplicity, task ownership, centralized communication, and documentation storage. However, it may require completely manual budget calculations

and external dependency maps. For the Martime database archive project, Trello can realistically only be mainly used in organizing and tracking work, while more analytical needs would need to be externally outsourced.

4. MS Project

The evaluation of MS Project is based on Microsoft's official documentation, direct testing with the 30 day free trial of the software, and supported by third party software reviews. MS Project is a Project Management Software created by Microsoft Co., leveraging Office 365's vast Suite of business tools to deliver an extensive IT infrastructure. Core components of MS Project will involve detailing how the software works, how MS Project uniquely addresses each of our selected project management activities, as well as cost, license terms, UI/UX, security considerations, and recent developments (Microsoft, 2021).

MS Project functions with an interface very similar to Excel, with numbered vertical tabs capturing the ID numbers of various tasks & subtasks. Tasks are structured as such: Task Name, Estimated Duration, Start, Finish, and Predecessors. On its right hand side is a Gantt Chart which visually maps each task based on its start to finish date. Users have the option to either manually schedule tasks or enable "auto scheduling", as found in the bottom left hand corner of the software. Users have the option to "indent tasks" - allowing the creation of subtasks, and automatically summing the overall time of the tasks according to each subtask's Estimated Duration - shown in the black brackets. Furthermore, users have the option to link tasks, for which one task will serve as the predecessor (must finish before the other) of the other task.

The task information Dialogue box is particularly useful, showing similarities between the Format Box (Ctrl + 1) in Excel. Tabs are separated into General, Predecessors, Resources, Advanced (Constraints), Notes, and Custom Fields. General is the tab for generic task information to be displayed in the task list. Predecessors are tasks that must be completed before the task at hand in order for the task to occur. Resources - such as human, material, and cost resources are such things that the task may need to be executed, which is exceptionally useful for such things as project budgeting. Advanced

(Constraints) involve such specifications as when the task is to start and when it is to finish - using ASAP (as soon as possible), ALAP (as late as possible), SNET (start no earlier than), FNET (finish no earlier than), and other constraints. Finally, Notes & Custom Fields allow for other personalized specifications to the tasks up to the PM's discretion. PM's also have options, as per MS Project, to set milestones (Constraints), create phases for a project, set up Resource sheets, add Resources, set Costs for tasks, and set a Baseline.

Project Management Activities:

Microsoft Project is highly effective for cost budgeting, especially in resource intensive environments (Smith & Bottorff, 2024). Its structure mirrors Excel, making it familiar for users who rely on spreadsheets, and it supports extensive keyboard shortcuts that reduce workflow friction. Budgets, cost allocations, and resource expenses can be organized with precision, giving project managers a clear and efficient financial planning interface.

Microsoft Project does not natively support communication features. Instead, it relies on integrations with other Microsoft applications, such as Loop, Teams, and Outlook (Fink, 2024). Loop in particular can function similarly to Notion, enabling collaborative documentation and real-time updates. However, because these tools are separate products, seamless communication typically requires additional subscriptions, which increases overall cost.

Additional Information:

For project management professionals, Microsoft Project is straightforward, but for those without PM experience, the learning curve is steep. Costs vary by plan (Microsoft, 2021):

- Project Plan 1 (\$10/user/month) offers core task and project tracking.
- Project Plan 3 (\$30/user/month) adds the desktop app, Gantt charts, resource management, and timesheets.
- Project Plan 5 (\$55/user/month) unlocks advanced features like portfolio analysis, demand management, and enterprise level planning.

The interface resembles Excel, which benefits users who prefer a grid-based environment. Project supports macros for automation, customizable cells, flexible scheduling tools, resource sheets, and constraint programming. However, its design is less modern and intuitive than tools like Trello or Basecamp, which may reduce user satisfaction despite Project's higher functionality.

Microsoft Project benefits from version control through OneDrive, allowing managers to review past versions or recover files. However, it lacks real time co editing, and unlike Excel, it does not offer features such as freezing panes. Effective use often requires multiple Microsoft products: Excel, Power BI, Loop, Teams, which limits its efficiency as a standalone PM solution.

Recent updates have improved resource based planning, enhanced integration with Azure and cloud services, and expanded support for notations such as Kubernetes-related workflows and Yourdon Coad modeling. Reporting tools have also been modernized, strengthening Project's position as a comprehensive, enterprise-grade planning system (Microsoft, 2021).

5. Basecamp

This critique draws on Basecamp's software reviews and exploration of the platform through its 30 day free trial workspace. To understand how Basecamp functions in practice, it is important to first outline the core communication features it provides. Basecamp's straightforward method for project communication involves several tools that help teams organize and centralize information. The Message Boards act as structured spaces for formal updates, announcements, and decisions, ensuring communication remains organized rather than being scattered across long chat threads or email chains. The chat feature supports informal, real-time communication, while Pings allow private messaging between two people. The Docs & Files area also assists team coordination by providing a space where documents, meeting notes, and project resources can be stored and accessed easily (Basecamp, 2019). Despite these communication benefits, Basecamp lacks communication planning tools such as stakeholder matrices,

communication schedules, or tracking dashboards. This limits its usefulness for projects that require structured communication governance and extensive planning across multiple channels.

When it comes to project scheduling tasks such as network planning, Basecamp is very limited. Network planning requires diagrams of activities, sequencing, and dependencies—functions typically served by Gantt charts or dependency diagrams. Basecamp offers no built-in features for dependency mapping or timeline modeling. Its To-Do lists can show task order, but they do not link dependencies or update scheduling relationships automatically. As a result, Basecamp works only for simple sequencing and becomes insufficient for larger, more complex projects that depend on detailed scheduling logic (Fink, 2024a).

Similarly, Basecamp does not support critical path analysis. Its lack of dependency structures, duration tracking, and timeline optimization tools makes it unable to identify the tasks that determine the shortest possible project duration. Critical tasks can only be monitored through manual use of To-Dos and the Schedule feature. While this may be manageable for smaller teams familiar with their project's key tasks, it becomes impractical for larger or time-sensitive projects where formal critical path management is essential.

Basecamp's restrictions also extend to budget management, as it lacks integrated financial monitoring and expense-reporting tools. Teams must track budgets outside the software using programs like Excel or Google Sheets, storing related files in Docs & Files. Although budget discussions can take place on Message Boards, Basecamp cannot support cost monitoring, earned value analysis, or real-time financial oversight. This makes the software viable only for teams whose financial requirements are minimal or managed entirely outside the platform.

Risk management is another area where Basecamp offers limited support. It does not include a risk registry, scoring system, ranking capabilities, or automated alerts. Teams can manually create a risk log in Docs & Files or list risks in a Message Board post, with To-Dos used to track mitigation tasks. While this allows for basic

documentation, it lacks the structured, ongoing monitoring required for formal risk-management frameworks.

Basecamp's alignment with Agile techniques is also limited. Although its communication-centered structure supports Agile principles like transparency and collaboration, and To-Do lists can represent user tasks, it lacks Agile-specific capabilities such as sprint boards, burndown charts, backlogs, velocity tracking, and customizable workflows. As a result, it may suffice for small teams but not for structured Scrum or scaled Agile environments that require analytics and consistent performance tracking.

Overall, Basecamp is a good tool for smaller projects that do not require in depth planning or do not mind performing tasks outside the software and bringing them together within Basecamp. This makes it unsuitable for our project, where the ability to create a communication plan and track budgets within the tool is important. The software's positives include its usability and its ability to store large amounts of information in the Files and Docs section, which supports team access. Basecamp may also support larger groups if the project does not demand substantial planning or oversight. These are the main themes taken away from the software.

6. Teamwork:

This critique uses Teamwork's documentation, online reviews, and hands on testing through the 30 day free trial. Teamwork stands as a top project management tool for teams with multiple projects across the globe. The tool offers a free plan for up to 5 users in addition to reasonably priced paid tiers (Baldikov, 2025). In terms of general usability, Teamwork performs strongly: it features a clean, minimalist interface that displays projects, deadlines, task progress, and updates in a visually organized manner. Quick-add buttons, drag-and-drop functionality, color coding, smart filters, and task templates further enhance the user experience, making routine actions efficient and intuitive (Teamwork, 2019).

- Layout and Design:

Teamwork's interface balances visualization with modular integration, consolidating project management, resource allocation, time tracking, file sharing, and communication within a single workspace (Teamwork, 2019). This unified dashboard reduces the need for switching between applications—an advantage for a project like the Maritime Archive system, which involves multiple stakeholders working across archival, educational, and technical tasks. Its flexible layout allows customization for different roles and preferences, although this high degree of configurability can become overwhelming for smaller teams or users who only require simple task lists.

- Unique Features and Budget Tracking Performance:

A key strength of Teamwork is its suite of financial tools. Teamwork includes built-in time tracking, billable vs. non-billable hour reporting, profitability analysis, and project-level budgeting. These features allow organizations to monitor planned and actual expenditure, set budget thresholds, and receive automated alerts when spending approaches predefined limits. Such capabilities directly support the Project Budget Tracker activity by enabling budgeting transparency, early detection of overspending, and clear documentation of financial trends (Teamwork, 2019). However, some advanced budgeting functions require upgrades to paid plans, which may challenge smaller nonprofits with limited budgets.

- Collaboration Tools and Communication Planning Performance:

Teamwork provides extensive communication tools that strongly support the Project Communication Plan. As noted by Kantor (2025), Teamwork Chat enables real time discussions, file attachments, and immediate feedback, significantly reducing reliance on email chains. The platform's mobile app also ensures that project members can remain updated regardless of location, which is valuable given the diverse availability of Maritime Heritage Society contributors. Task-level comments, @mentions, shared files, and project updates help centralize communication around deliverables. Administrators can also tailor notification settings and control visibility to maintain structured and consistent information flow throughout the project lifecycle.

Overall, Teamwork delivers a rich set of features that support both communication management and budget tracking. Its limitations lie in its complexity and the cost of unlocking advanced budgeting tools, which may reduce its suitability for smaller organizations without technical support.

Section 5:

There was no one software package that was a perfect fit for the Maritime Archive project because each one had its own way of balancing ease of use, features, and scalability. We looked at six platforms, MS Project, Genius Project, Teamwork, ClickUp, Trello, and Basecamp, to see how well they worked together and to find patterns in their strengths and weaknesses.

Genius Project is a full fledged enterprise system that has structured documentation control, formal communication workflows, and a built in risk register. These features give large businesses the level of traceability and governance they need. But for the Maritime Heritage Society, whose contributors include volunteers and non technical board members, the system is too complicated and hard to learn in nine months, which is the project's deadline. Genius Project is very powerful, but it needs a lot more organizational capacity than a small heritage institution has.

Basecamp and Trello, on the other hand, are both built around making things simple, clear, and easy to use. Basecamp is great for communication through message boards, chats, to do lists, and file sharing. However, it doesn't have advanced scheduling, critical path analysis, or any kind of built in budgeting. Trello is great for light coordination because it has visually appealing Kanban boards with customizable labels, due dates, and Butler automation. Trello also doesn't have financial tracking or dependency mapping, which makes it less useful for projects that need structured budgeting and analytical oversight. No platform can handle the level of planning rigor that this project needs on its own.

MS Project has the most advanced technical features, such as detailed cost budgeting, Gantt charts, dependency mapping, and scheduling for the most important paths. These features are best for projects that need a lot of resources and are managed by teams with formal project management training. It also makes it harder for small teams with different levels of experience to use because it needs other Microsoft apps to communicate.

Teamwork is somewhere in the middle between simple and complex systems. It has features for tracking time, billing, client access, customizable dashboards, and good communication. It has a lot of features, but the interface can be too much for smaller teams, and some budgeting tools need upgraded plans.

ClickUp is the best all around choice. It is a low cost platform that combines visual project views, structured communication tools, and flexible budget tracking. ClickUp has one of the best overall combinations of accessibility, collaboration, and scheduling features, even though its interface can be cluttered, and it doesn't have advanced financial modeling.

In short, teams that value simplicity might choose Basecamp or Trello, while teams that need more advanced analytical tools might choose MS Project or Genius Project. ClickUp and Teamwork have the most balanced features. ClickUp is the best choice for projects that need both a way to communicate and a way to see the budget.

Section 6:

ClickUp is the most suitable software solution for the Maritime Archive Information System project because it offers the strongest alignment with both of the team's selected project management activities: communication planning and budget tracking. Unlike MS Project or Genius Project, ClickUp does not require extensive training, complex configuration, or additional integrated applications for basic collaboration. Its interface supports multiple stakeholder types, including board members, educators, developers, and volunteer archivists, through a combination of task lists, dashboards, Gantt charts, Kanban boards, and comment-based communication threads that directly reinforce the communication needs outlined in Section 3.

ClickUp's structured communication tools allow the project team to assign responsibilities, maintain decision logs, store documentation, and ensure that updates flow consistently across the nine-month project timeline. These features directly support the communication plan's requirements for regular reporting, stakeholder-specific updates, and transparent documentation. The notification system and task-level comment threads minimize information gaps and keep all contributors synchronized.

For budget tracking, ClickUp enables teams to establish custom cost fields, track estimated versus actual expenses, and build dashboards that display spending trends and remaining funds. Although advanced financial modeling will still be performed in Excel, ClickUp's tracking tools are sufficient to support the project's grant-compliance obligations and monthly reporting to the board. The platform also accommodates the contingency fund and provides visibility into cost variances as they develop.

ClickUp's cost structure, offering unlimited users in its free tier and affordable upgrades, makes it a sustainable option for a nonprofit organization with a mix of staff and volunteers. Its combination of usability, collaborative communication features, and integrated cost tracking capabilities make it the only platform that fully addresses the operational, financial, and organizational needs of the Maritime Archive project without overwhelming its users or exceeding resource constraints.

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